Paes describes their grand nine-day Dussehra festival. All the chiefs, governors and dancing women of the kingdom attend. It's a time of feasting, ceremony, ritual and prayer, dancing, circus acts, martial parades, wrestling and other games, fireworks, gift giving and more. 'Their wrestling,' writes Paes, 'does not seem like ours, but there are blows (given), so severe as to break teeth, and put out eyes, and disfigure faces, so much so that here and there men are carried off speechless by their friends.' For nine days, people fast all day and eat at midnight, shortly before which the king witnesses the sacrificial slaughter of twenty-four buffaloes and 150 sheep, their heads severed in a single blow. After the festival is over, the king parades his forces on the outskirts of the city, both his own and of his feudatory chiefs and governors, with soldiers, horses and elephants decked out in all their finery—a noisy, fearsome, testosterone-driven display of the king's military might to all his enemies.

Fernao Nuniz

Fernao Nuniz, a Portuguese merchant and horse trader, spent three years in Vijayanagar (1535–37). His long account also covers the kingdom's early history, but he is more reliable when closer to his own time. This includes Krishnadevaraya's victorious 1513 war against the Gajapati kings of Orissa. To commemorate his win, he built the grand Krishna Temple and installed an idol of infant Krishna that he stole during a temple raid in Orissa. Nuniz also describes in fair detail the Battle of Raichur in 1520 between Krishnadevaraya and Adil Shah, the sultan of Bijapur. Nuniz must have spoken to men who participated in these wars.

Nuniz writes that Krishnadevaraya, lusting after Raichur and its lucrative hinterland, found a flimsy pretext to go to war with the sultan of Bijapur, breaking a peace of four decades. Summoning his regional 'captains', or governors, with their armies, he marched towards Raichur with 500,000 infantry—'archers, men with shields, musketeers, and spearmen'—32,000 cavalry and 500 elephants. Alongside came the support staff: 'numberless' washermen, thousands of men with waterskins, merchants with all sorts of city goods, Brahmins for 'ceremonies and sacrifices', drummers, musicians and 20,000 courtesans for the army men. Their large camps 'were divided into regular streets' with markets that sold meats, grains, vegetables and